90 Jonah

The runaway prophet who learned that God's mercy is wider than his own.

Jonah was a prophet of the northern kingdom in the days of King Jeroboam II. At home he brought good news: God would restore Israel's borders. But when God sent him to Nineveh, the great city of Israel's enemy Assyria, Jonah ran the other way. A storm, a great fish and a second call brought him to Nineveh at last. He preached, and the whole city repented. Instead of rejoicing, Jonah was angry, because he had known all along that God was gracious. The book ends with God's question to him, still unanswered. Jesus pointed to Jonah as a sign of his own death and resurrection, and to Nineveh as a people who repented when they heard.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Yonah*, "dove"
Family	Son of Amittai (Jonah 1:1; 2 Kings 14:25)
Home	Gath-hepher in Zebulun (2 Kings 14:25; Joshua 19:13)
When	Reign of Jeroboam II of Israel, c. 793–753 BC
Key places	Joppa, the sea, Nineveh
Key people	Jeroboam II, the sailors, the king and people of Nineveh
Main passages	Jonah 1–4; 2 Kings 14:23–27
New Testament	Matthew 12:39–41; 16:4; Luke 11:29–32

> *"And should not I spare Nineveh, that great city, wherein are more than sixscore thousand persons that cannot discern between their right hand and their left hand; and also much cattle?"*
>
> Jonah 4:11, KJV

The life of Jonah

Dates are approximate (BC). The book of Jonah does not say when he went to Nineveh. Christians differ on how to read it: most have read it as history, while some read it as a teaching story built around a real prophet.

c. 790–760 BC
Reign of Jeroboam II

A word of hope

Jonah foretells that Israel's borders will be restored from the entering of Hamath to the Dead Sea. Jeroboam II wins them back, as the LORD had spoken. *2 Kings 14:23–27*

Date uncertain

Called and runs

God tells Jonah to go and cry against Nineveh. He goes down to Joppa, pays the fare, and boards a ship for Tarshish, fleeing "from the presence of the LORD." *Jonah 1:1–3*

At sea

The storm

A great wind threatens the ship while Jonah sleeps below. The lot falls on him. He tells the sailors to throw him overboard, and the sea grows calm. *Jonah 1:4–16*

Three days and three nights

In the great fish

The LORD prepares a great fish to swallow Jonah. From inside it he prays, and the fish casts him out on dry land. *Jonah 1:17–2:10*

At Nineveh

The second call

The word of the LORD comes a second time. Jonah walks into the great city and cries, "Yet forty days, and Nineveh shall be overthrown." *Jonah 3:1–4*

At Nineveh

The city repents

The people believe God, fast and put on sackcloth. The king sits in ashes and orders everyone to turn from violence. God relents and spares them. *Jonah 3:5–10*

East of the city

Anger and the gourd

Jonah is angry and asks to die. God grows a plant to shade him, then sends a worm to kill it, and asks whether Jonah does well to be angry. *Jonah 4:1–11*

Key activities

The Hebrew says "a great fish," not a whale. The King James New Testament says "whale's belly" (Matthew 12:40), translating a Greek word for a large sea creature. Tarshish was probably far to the west, perhaps in Spain.

1. **Prophesied good news.** He spoke the word that Israel's lost borders would return, even under a king who did evil. *2 Kings 14:25–27*
2. **Ran from God.** Told to go east to Nineveh, he went west toward Tarshish. *Jonah 1:1–3*
3. **Slept through the storm.** While the pagan sailors prayed to their gods, he lay fast asleep in the ship. *Jonah 1:5–6*
4. **Confessed his faith.** He told the sailors, "I fear the LORD, the God of heaven, which hath made the sea and the dry land." *Jonah 1:8–10*
5. **Gave himself up.** He told them to throw him into the sea. They did, the storm stopped, and the sailors feared the LORD and made vows. *Jonah 1:11–16*
6. **Prayed from the deep.** Inside the fish he gave thanks and declared, "Salvation is of the LORD." *Jonah 2:1–9*
7. **Obeyed the second time.** He went to Nineveh and delivered a short, blunt warning. *Jonah 3:1–4*
8. **Saw a city repent.** From the king down, Nineveh turned from its evil ways, and God spared it. *Jonah 3:5–10*
9. **Complained about mercy.** He said he had fled because he knew God was "gracious ... and merciful, slow to anger, and of great kindness." *Jonah 4:1–3*
10. **Sulked outside the city.** He built a shelter and waited to see what would happen to Nineveh. *Jonah 4:5*
11. **Was questioned by God.** God used a plant, a worm and a hot east wind to show Jonah his own heart. *Jonah 4:6–11*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jonah.

Old Testament

2 Kings 14:23–27	His only mention outside his book: home and prophecy
Jonah 1–4	The full account of his mission to Nineveh
Jonah 4:2; Exodus 34:6; Joel 2:13	Jonah quotes God's classic self-description
Nahum 1:1; 3:1–7	Nineveh's fall foretold; it fell in 612 BC
Echo: 1 Kings 19:3–4	Elijah also ran and asked to die

New Testament

Matthew 12:39–41; Luke 11:29–32	"The sign of the prophet Jonas"; "a greater than Jonas is here"
Matthew 16:4	No sign but the sign of Jonas
Echo: Mark 4:35–41	Jesus sleeps in a storm and calms the sea
Echo: Acts 10:5–35	At Joppa, Peter is sent to Gentiles
Tradition	A tomb of Jonah at Nebi Yunus, Mosul (tradition only)

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What reason did Jonah give for running away (Jonah 4:2)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think the book ends with God's question instead of Jonah's answer?
3. *Apply:* Is there a person or group you would secretly rather God did not bless? What would it take to pray for them this week?
4. *Apply:* Jonah obeyed the second time. Where is God giving you a second chance to do something you avoided?